problems that need to be addressed. Importantly though, this differs from the *liberal* narrative of democratization in that it is sceptical of the role of formal institutions or procedures in resolving the tensions and conflict inherent in politics. Rather, the *equality* narrative offers a deeper critique of Bamar culture, emphasizing the authoritarian tendencies not only in government but also throughout society.

Thus, between Western donor representatives and Bamar activists and opposition leaders, there is a range of contrasting reactions to the issue of communal violence. I have attempted to demonstrate that these reactions are not just isolated perspectives — which can be explained as irrational or disingenuous — but rather sit in contrasting overarching narratives of the country's democratization. These narratives emphasize different sets of core values and different ways of containing, or rising above, the tensions and conflicts of political life.

CONCLUSION: BEYOND FIXED MEANINGS OF "DEMOCRACY"

Communal violence and Muslim–Buddhist tensions have led to polarized reactions, and there are new lines of fracture between the international aid community and the Bamar democracy movement, and also new divisions in the opposition. I have argued that connecting reactions to communal violence to deeper and contrasting narratives of democratization can help explain why there has been such divergence. Thus assumptions about the meaning of "democracy" are critical in making sense of responses to communal violence.

Importantly, if "democracy" is seen to have a single, universal meaning based in "human rights", then the anti-Muslim perspectives expressed by some in the democracy movement can only be explained as crazy or insincere. In contrast, if democracy is considered to be an "essentially contested concept" (Gallie 1956) — where there is no fixed way of determining its meaning — then connections are revealed between reactions to communal violence and contrasting narratives about the country's democratization.

Given the country's fractious modern history, it is no surprise that within the opposition movement the values of unity and protection of the majority are prominent in debates about the meaning of "democracy".